

Johann Neumann

Johann Balthasar Neumann (1687–1753) was a late baroque architect working mainly in the towns of Würzburg and Bamberg in Bavaria. His original style amalgamated Austrian, Bohemian, Italian and French elements, creating commanding and well-balanced buildings, and he introduced the new rococo style to his interiors.

Neumann's work was exceptionally precise yet light-hearted, playful and colourful, with none of the heaviness of some baroque architecture. He used symmetry and harmony to create astonishing visual effects, mainly for churches and palaces such as the Würzburg Residenz (1720–44, opposite). Domes and barrel vaults enhance the illusion of elegance, while light streams through huge windows onto lavish ornamentation, murals and gilding. His Wallfahrtskirche or 'pilgrim's church' (1730–9) in the town of Gossweinstein was a colossal sandstone building with two high towers facing the town. His final work, the Marienkirche at Limbach (1747–52), is a masterpiece of the baroque style.

